

The Inner Work

The mental and emotional preparation guide
for anyone about to make a big life change.

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Proof that it is never too late to choose yourself.

A Note Before You Begin

I did not do this work before I moved to Madrid. I did it after, slowly, in the gaps between bureaucratic appointments and long walks through neighborhoods where nobody knew my name yet. I wish I had done it before.

Not because it would have made the move easier, exactly. But because I would have arrived knowing myself a little better. Knowing why I was really there. Knowing which fears were worth listening to and which ones were just noise from a life I had already outgrown.

This workbook is not a checklist. It will not tell you whether to go. That is not its job. Its job is to make sure that when you do go, you go on purpose, with clarity, and with your eyes open to both what you are gaining and what you are genuinely leaving behind.

Write in this. Seriously. The prompts are not rhetorical. The lines are there because something happens when you put a pen to paper that does not happen when you think the same thought in the shower. Do not perform your answers. Nobody is reading this but you.

Work through the sections in order if you can. They build on each other. Come back to ones that feel unfinished. There is no grade and no deadline. This is just you, getting honest with yourself before you do the bravest thing you have probably done in a long time.

It is not too late. I promise you that much.

SECTION 1

Why You're Really Doing This

There is the answer you give people at dinner parties and there is the real one. The dinner party version is tidy. It involves phrases like: I have always wanted to, life is short, the cost of living. People nod. You move on.

The real answer is messier. It might involve a marriage that ended. A career that stopped meaning anything. A birthday that hit harder than you expected. A moment of standing in your kitchen on a Tuesday afternoon thinking: this cannot be all there is.

Both answers can be true simultaneously. But you need to know the real one. Because you are going to have hard days in Madrid, days when the bureaucracy wins and the loneliness lands and you question every decision you made. On those days, the dinner party answer will not be enough to hold you. The real one might.

Reflect:

"What is the version of this decision I tell other people?"

"What is the version I have not said out loud yet?"

"If I am honest with myself, am I running toward something or away from something? What specifically?"

“What would have to be true about my life for me to stay and feel genuinely at peace with that choice?”

SECTION 2

What Fear Is Telling You

Fear showed up when I bought my plane ticket. It showed up again when I told my family. It showed up approximately forty more times before I landed in Barajas. It has never fully gone away, and I have made my peace with that.

Here is what I learned: not all fear is the same. Some fear is protective. It is your nervous system flagging something real, a genuine risk, a gap in your plan, something you have not thought through. That fear is worth listening to. It has useful information.

Other fear is just the sound of your life changing. It is not warning you about danger. It is warning you about difference. That fear is not a stop sign. It is proof that what you are doing actually matters to you.

The work is learning to tell them apart.

Fear Inventory:

List every fear you have about this move, large and small. Do not edit yourself.

Now sort them:

Fears with real information (something I need to research, plan, or solve)	Fears that are just fear (the sound of my life changing)

"For the fears in the left column: what is the one concrete thing I could do this week to address each one?"

"For the fears in the right column: what would I say to a close friend who had these exact fears about a move she was excited about?"

SECTION 3

What You're Leaving Behind

Nobody talks about the grief. Everyone talks about the adventure, the freedom, the fresh start. And those things are real. But so is what you leave.

I left a city I knew like the back of my hand. I left the shorthand you build with people over decades. I left the ability to navigate a bad day without also navigating a language. I left proximity. To family, to friends, to the version of myself that felt known.

Letting yourself feel that is not weakness and it is not doubt. It is honesty. The move can be right and the loss can be real at the same time. If you do not let yourself grieve what you are leaving, it will find you later, usually at 2am in a city where you do not know anyone yet.

Write it all down:

"What am I actually leaving behind? Not just things and places, but feelings, roles, and relationships."

"Which of these losses am I minimizing because it is easier than acknowledging them?"

“Which relationships in my life are strong enough to survive distance, and which ones am I privately worried about?”

“What does it mean to grieve something you are also choosing? Write about that.”

You are allowed to be sad about what you are leaving and excited about where you are going. These are not contradictory. They are just evidence that the life you are leaving was actually worth something.

SECTION 4

Who Are You Without Your Context?

This one surprised me more than anything else.

I knew who I was at home. I was the person who knew which coffee shop had the best corner seat. I was the person my friends called with certain kinds of problems. I had a reputation, a history, a place in the ecosystem of my city. None of that traveled.

In Madrid, for a long time, I was just a woman trying to understand her electricity bill. Nobody knew what I had done before. Nobody knew how I usually was. I had to figure out who I was when none of my context was doing the work for me.

That is terrifying and it is also the point. The version of you that exists independent of your history, your roles, your reputation, the names other people have given you over the years. That is the version that gets to show up in a new city. It is worth meeting her before you go.

Reflect:

"How do I currently define myself? List the roles, titles, and identities I hold."

"Which of these identities are genuinely mine and which ones did I inherit, perform, or settle into by default?"

“If I moved somewhere where nobody knew anything about me, what would I want them to eventually know?”

“What part of myself have I not had space to be in my current life?”

“What do I value so fundamentally that it will be true of me regardless of where I live?”

SECTION 5

The Relationships That Will Change

Some relationships will surprise you by getting stronger. Distance forces intention, and intention turns out to be what some friendships needed all along. A phone call becomes a ritual. A visit becomes something you both protect.

Other relationships will quietly fade. Not because anyone did anything wrong, but because what held them together was proximity and habit, and when those are gone, there is not enough left. This is painful and it is also honest.

The ones that hurt the most are the relationships where you are not sure which category they fall into yet. The ones where you hope, but you do not know.

Have the conversations before you go. Not to resolve everything, but to give the people you love the chance to show up for this with you.

Relationship Audit:

Think about the people who matter most to you. Write their names or initials and then honestly assess each one.

Person	What holds this relationship together?	Will it survive distance?	What does it need from me?

"Is there a conversation I have been avoiding having before I go? What am I afraid will happen if I have it?"

“What do I need from the people I love during this transition, and have I actually told them?”

SECTION 6

Permission

This section is specifically for anyone who has been told, directly or indirectly, that the window for a life like this has closed.

You are too old. You should be settling down, not starting over. What about your retirement? What will people think? Is it not a little selfish? Is it not a little reckless? Should you not be grateful for what you have?

I heard versions of all of these. Some were said out loud by people who loved me. Most were said quietly by a part of me that had internalized a story about what a woman at this stage of life is supposed to want.

Here is what I know now: nobody is coming to give you permission. Not your family. Not your friends. Not a sign from the universe. You have to give it to yourself, and you have to do it before you feel ready, because ready is not a feeling that arrives on its own. Ready is what happens after you decide.

Reflect:

"Whose voice do I hear most loudly when I doubt myself about this decision?"

"What story have I been told about what women like me are supposed to want at this point in life?"

"Where did that story come from, and do I actually believe it?"

“Write the permission slip you have been waiting for someone else to give you. Write it to yourself, in your own words.”

You are not too late. You are not too old. You are not too much or too little of anything. You are a person who wants something and is trying to figure out how to be brave enough to go get it. That is not a midlife crisis. That is just being alive.

SECTION 7

The Life You're Actually Building

Vague visions do not sustain you when things get hard. A beautiful feeling about a future life is not the same as a picture of it. When the bureaucracy is a nightmare and the apartment search is taking weeks and you have eaten alone for the fifth night in a row, a feeling will not be enough to hold you.

A picture might be.

This section is about getting specific. Not about logistics, you have another guide for that. About the texture of daily life. What does Tuesday look like? Where do you have coffee? What is the quality of your mornings? Who do you eventually become friends with? What do you do with the freedom you are moving toward?

The more specific you can make this, the more real it becomes. And the more real it becomes, the more it can hold you on the days when the abstract idea of a new life is not enough.

Build the picture:

"Describe a perfect ordinary Tuesday in the life I am building. Be specific about place, time, feeling, and detail."

"What does my social life look like one year in? Where do I meet people, what do we do, what does belonging feel like in a new city?"

“What do I want to be doing, making, or building in this new chapter that I have not had space for in my current life?”

“Three years from now, if this goes the way I hope, what does my life look like and how do I feel about the decision I made?”

SECTION 8

When It Gets Hard

It will get hard. I want to say that plainly so it is not a surprise when it happens.

There will be a day, probably within the first three months, when something breaks down at the same time as something else breaks down and you are tired and you do not have your people around you and you will question every single decision that led you to that moment.

That day does not mean you made a mistake. It means you are doing something hard. Those are different things and it will be easy to confuse them in the moment.

The people who come through the hard days are not the ones who do not feel them. They are the ones who prepared for them. Who knew in advance what they were anchored to, what they would say to themselves, who they would call, and what they would do to get through the next 24 hours.

Prepare now. When you are clear-headed and still excited. Because that version of you is smarter about this than the version who is sitting on the floor of a Madrid apartment at midnight wondering what she has done.

Build your anchor:

“What is the core reason I am doing this? Write it in one or two sentences, plainly, so I can read it on a hard day.”

“Who are the one or two people I can call at any hour when I am struggling? What do I need them to say or do?”

“What has helped me get through hard things in the past? What do I know about how I recover?”

“Write a letter from your future self, one year in, to the version of you who is sitting in a hard moment doubting everything. What does she want you to know?”

One Last Question

Take as much space as you need. There is no right answer. There is only yours.

“What would you do if you weren’t afraid?”

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